

# That's what (s)he said

Steve Carrell has got big shoes to fill.

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**F**or many college students, graduation brings an onslaught of questions as students ask what they want to do and who they want to be. Commencement addresses, given by a successful alumni or influential individuals, offer graduates guiding principles and lessons as they embark into life after college. As graduation season quickly approaches, here are four of the most memorable speakers in Northwestern's history and words of wisdom they shared.



Ruth Bader Ginsburg spoke to Northwestern's graduating class of 1998 while serving as an associate justice of the United States Supreme Court. She joked that she chose Northwestern because it was the only place where she "could be cast in the same role as Robert Redford and Bill Cosby," two other notable past speakers. Her speech centered around the fight for gender equality in professional and academic settings. One student called Ginsburg's address "definitely the best part of the ceremonies," *The Daily Northwestern* reported in June of that year.

**"I continue to gain encouragement from the example of those who, despite great odds, have persevered in the pursuit of justice, and who, like you, have chosen to make a difference."**  
— Ruth Bader Ginsburg (1998)



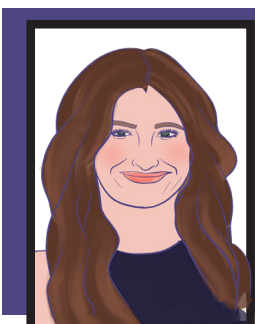
Two months prior to President Obama's visit, *The Daily* printed a column by Elaine Meyer (Weinberg '06), who called upon the then-state senator to challenge the senior class in his commencement address. Standing in Ryan Field on a muggy June day, with a commanding voice and charismatic demeanor, Obama responded to Meyer's request. He based his speech on themes of personal responsibility, perseverance and empathy, while also situating it in the social and political issues of the time.

**"There's a lot of talk in this country about the federal deficit. But I think we should talk more about our empathy deficit — the ability to put ourselves in someone else's shoes; to see the world through those who are different from us."** — Barack Obama (2006)



Many Northwestern alumni say they wouldn't be where they are today without this university. For Seth Meyers (Speech '96), that statement is literal — the *Late Night* host told graduates his parents met in a Northwestern poetry class. Meyers focused his 2016 commencement speech on the friendships he made at Northwestern. As one graduating senior told *The Daily*, "whether it is in medicine, law, engineering, consulting, whatever career path we may choose to follow, I hope we can use our Northwestern experience and find the same hard-earned success that Seth has found."

**"You've been surrounded by the best for the last four years and there's no better favor you will do yourself than continuing to do that. Every success I've had has been thanks to the people around me."** — Seth Meyers (2016)



Most students would say that Northwestern dining halls are a place of mediocre food, long lines and the occasional existential crisis. Not many would describe them as places to meet your future life partner, but for actress and Northwestern alumna Kathryn Hahn (Speech '95), that was exactly the case. Hahn met her husband in the former Hinman Dining Hall as first-years. In 2024, she returned to Northwestern to address the graduating class. In her speech, she acknowledged that life often encompasses contradictory emotions and situations and thus encouraged graduates to adopt a "both/and" mindset.

**"While it is true that at this very moment, yes, there is unimaginable pain and suffering in this world, it is also true that you and your class are going through something together that is once-in-a-lifetime and worthy of celebration."** — Kathryn Hahn (2024)